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CUET UG

History

Colonialism and Rural Society

Theme 9 · Evidence from Official Reports · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

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Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

Sub-Topic Domain	Official NTA CUET UG Unit IX Syllabus Scope	High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested
Bengal & Zamindars	Permanent Settlement (1793); Lord Cornwallis; Burdwan public auction (1797); **Sunset Law**; causes of zamindari arrears; rise of **Jotedars** (**haoladars**, **gantidars**); sharecroppers (**adhiyars** / **bargadars**); zamindari survival strategies (**benami** transfers, female property exemption, **lathyals**).	Analyzing institutional mechanics; evaluating fiscal pressure; contrasting rural power hierarchies between absentee landlords and resident village elites.
The Fifth Report (1813)	British Parliamentary Select Committee on East India Company; 1,002 folio pages; 800+ pages of statistical appendices; attacks on Company monopoly; political bias of select committee; historiographical critique of exaggerated zamindari collapse.	Historiographical source criticism; deconstructing colonial administrative motives; distinguishing between official rhetoric and ground realities.
Hoe vs Plough (Rajmahal)	Francis Buchanan's surveys; **Paharias** (shifting cultivation, **kural** / hoe, mahua gathering, charcoal production); Augustus Cleveland's pacification; **Santhals** (sedentary plough agriculture); British colonial vision of civilized frontier; **Damin-i-Koh** (1832).	Interpreting ecological and symbolic conflicts; evaluating frontier colonization policies; analyzing contrasting modes of tribal subsistence.
The Santhal Hul (1855–56)	Moneylenders (**dikus**); extortionate interest rates; zamindari land alienation; messianic leadership of **Sidhu** and **Kanhu Murmu**; **Thakurji's** divine mandate; rebellion trajectory; martial law suppression; creation of **Santhal Pargana** district (1855).	Tracing subaltern rebellion chronology; analyzing religious legitimation in peasant revolts; evaluating colonial legislative concessions.
Bombay Deccan & Ryotwari	Ryotwari settlement; Ricardian economic rent theory; direct state-peasant contract; periodic 30-year revisions; exorbitant initial assessments (50%+ of gross produce); peasant indebtedness and village desertions in 1820s–1830s.	Evaluating theoretical economic models in colonial practice; comparing regional fiscal frameworks; analyzing peasant vulnerability to price drops.
Cotton Boom & Deccan Riots	American Civil War (1861–65); Cotton Supply Association; flow of credit to Deccan **ryots**; post-war slump; **Limitation Law of 1859** (3-year bond validity); **Supa** uprising (May 1875); burning of **bahikhatas**; Deccan Riots Commission (1878); 1879 Relief Act.	Tracing global commodity linkages; diagnosing mechanisms of debt trap and bond manipulation; analyzing symbolic peasant collective action.

CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

Theme 9 requires sharp differentiation between colonial official rhetoric and socio-economic realities:

1. **The Symbolic Duality of Tools:** In NCERT, the conflict in the Rajmahal hills is framed as the epic battle between the **Hoe** and the **Plough**:
   - **The Hoe:** Symbolized the **Paharias**, who practiced shifting cultivation, lived off forest produce, and resisted colonial subjugation.
   - **The Plough:** Symbolized the **Santhals**, settled agriculturalists whom the British invited to clear forests, practice sedentary farming, and pay land revenue.
2. **Zamindar vs Jotedar:**
   - **Zamindars:** Absentee proprietors living in urban mansions (Calcutta), responsible for paying fixed revenue to the Company under the Sunset Law.
   - **Jotedars:** Rich **resident** peasants living inside the villages of North Bengal (also called **haoladars**, **gantidars**, or **mandals**). They owned thousands of acres, controlled village moneylending, and actively sabotaged zamindari revenue collection.
3. **The Limitation Law of 1859:** It did NOT reduce interest rates; it made loan bonds legally valid for only **three years**. Moneylenders circumvented this by forcing illiterate ryots to sign new bonds every three years, adding unpaid accumulated interest into the principal.
4. **The Deccan Riots Target:** Peasants in May 1875 did not target lives or British treasury vaults; they engaged in **symbolic violence**, attacking moneylenders' shops to seize and publicly burn debt bonds, promissory notes, and account books (**bahi-khatas**).
5. **Deccan Riots Commission Report (1878):** The Commission deliberately absolved the colonial government and its exorbitant revenue demand, laying the blame entirely on usurious moneylenders and alleged peasant spending extravagance.

1. Bengal and the Zamindars: The Permanent Settlement of 1793

Colonial rule was first established in Bengal, where the British East India Company attempted to reorder rural society and establish an unshakeable fiscal foundation for its expanding imperial state:

An Auction in Burdwan (1797)

In **1797**, an extensive public auction was held at Burdwan (present-day Bardhaman in West Bengal). Numerous **mahals** (revenue estates) belonging to the Raja of Burdwan were being auctioned off by the British East India Company to recover unpaid revenue arrears.

However, British collectors soon discovered a bizarre outcome:

- Almost all the highest bidders at the auction were servants, secret agents, and confidential retainers of the Raja himself.
- Over 95 percent of the sales were entirely **fictitious** (**benami**). The Raja's agents outbid outside purchasers, intentionally defaulted on paying the purchase price, forced the Company to re-auction the land, and eventually bought back the estates at a fraction of their original assessed valuation.

Mechanics of the Permanent Settlement (1793)

The **Permanent Settlement** was enacted in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa in **1793** under the governor-generalship of **Lord Charles Cornwallis**:

- **Property Conversion:** Traditional regional **rajas** and **taluqdars** were legally recognized as **Zamindars** (proprietors of the soil).

- **Invariable Revenue:** The revenue demand payable to the Company was **fixed in perpetuity**. The British assumed that a fixed demand would encourage zamindars to invest capital in improving agricultural productivity, draining swamps, and expanding cultivation, secure in the knowledge that the state would not claim increased taxes.
- **The Sunset Law:** The administration enforced uncompromising payment discipline. Under the **Sunset Law**, if the stipulated revenue installment was not deposited in the Company's treasury by sunset of the specified date, the zamindar's estate was immediately liable to be confiscated and auctioned to the highest bidder.

Why Zamindars Defaulted: The Quadruple Crisis

During the initial decades following 1793, over 75 percent of zamindari estates were auctioned. The causes of widespread defaults included:

1. **Excessive Initial Assessment:** Expecting future agricultural expansion that they could never tax, the British deliberately set the initial revenue assessment artificially high.
2. **Agricultural Depression of the 1790s:** High revenue was imposed during a period of depressed grain prices. Cultivators could not sell their crops at prices high enough to pay their dues to the zamindar.
3. **Inelastic State Demand:** The revenue was invariant regardless of monsoon failure, floods, or crop devastation.
4. **Curtailed Judicial & Police Powers:** The Company severely restricted the traditional coercive authority of zamindars:
   - Zamindars' private armed retainers were disbanded.
   - Local customs duties were abolished.
   - Their **kacharis** (revenue courts) were placed under the supervision of a British Collector.
   - The local police (**thanas**) were placed under the control of government-appointed **darogas**, stripping zamindars of the power to coerce defaulting peasants.

The Rise of the Jotedars

While traditional zamindars struggled, a class of rich peasants known as **Jotedars** consolidated power in the villages of North Bengal (especially Dinajpur, Rangpur, and Jalpaiguri):

- **Regional Nomenclature:** Jotedars were also referred to as **haoladars**, **gantidars**, or **mandals**.
- **Economic Base:** They controlled thousands of acres of land, dominated local village moneylending, and engaged in grain trade.
- **Sharecropping System:** Jotedars did not cultivate land directly; they rented out their land to sharecroppers known as **adhiyars** or **bargadars**, who brought their own plows, provided labor, and surrendered half the harvested crop (**half-share**) to the jotedar.
- **Subverting the Zamindar:** Unlike absentee zamindars who lived in grand urban mansions in Calcutta, jotedars resided directly within the villages. They actively incited poor peasants to delay paying rents to the zamindar, resisted zamindari revenue collectors (**amlah**), and bought up auctioned zamindari estates when the zamindar defaulted.

Strategies of Zamindari Survival

Confronted with the Sunset Law and auctions, zamindars developed sophisticated survival strategies:

- **Benami Transfers:** The Raja of Burdwan transferred substantial portions of his zamindari to his mother, knowing that the Company's law strictly prohibited the attachment or auction of women's personal property.

- **Auction Manipulation:** When an estate was put up for auction, the zamindar's agents bid astronomical amounts to drive away genuine outside purchasers. The agents then refused to deposit the purchase money. The estate had to be re-auctioned repeatedly, driving the price down until the zamindar repurchased his own land through nominees.
- **Physical Intimidation:** If an outsider managed to purchase an estate, the zamindar's retainers (**lathyals**, club-wielding men) physically attacked the new purchaser's agents and evicted them. Village peasants, loyal to their traditional raja, refused to acknowledge outside purchasers. Between 1793 and 1801, four of the largest zamindaris in Bengal, including Burdwan, engineered fictitious sales to survive intact.

2. The Fifth Report and the Historiographical Archive (1813)

Context and Purpose of the Fifth Report

The **Fifth Report** was the fifth in a series of administrative reports submitted to the British Parliament in **1813** by a Select Committee appointed to inquire into the governance and commerce of the East India Company:

- **Monopoly Challenge:** In Britain, private merchants, industrialists, and political figures agitated against the East India Company's royal monopoly over trade with India and China. They sought access to Indian markets and seized upon instances of Company misgovernance.
- **Documentary Composition:** The report ran into **1,002 folio pages**, of which over **800 pages** consisted of statistical appendices, copies of collectors' official letters, judicial court minutes, and petitions of distressed zamindars.

Critical Historiographical Evaluation

For over a century, historians accepted the **Fifth Report** at face value as conclusive proof of the universal collapse of traditional Bengal landed society under the Permanent Settlement. Modern historical scholarship, however, offers a nuanced critique:

- **Political Bias:** The Select Committee was politically motivated to paint a bleak portrait of Company misrule to justify the British Parliament revoking the Company's trade monopoly (enacted through the **Charter Act of 1813**).
- **Exaggerated Ruin:** The report exaggerated the extent of zamindari collapse. While many small estates were indeed broken up, the great zamindaris survived through **benami** transactions and legal chicanery.

3. Comparative Architecture: Permanent Settlement vs Ryotwari

To grasp how colonial land settlements transformed different regions of India, the comparative architecture below juxtaposes Bengal's Permanent Settlement with the Bombay Deccan's Ryotwari system:

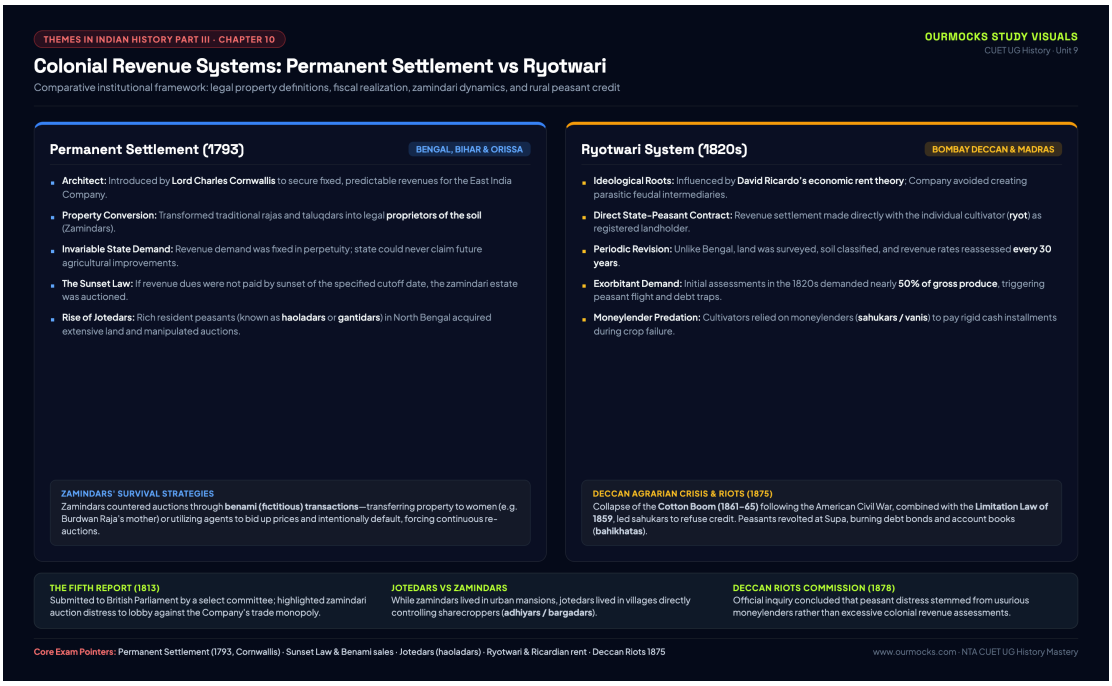


Figure 1: Figure 1 — Comparative Framework of Colonial Land Revenue Systems: Structural contrast between Bengal's Permanent Settlement and the Bombay Deccan's Ryotwari System.

Structural Contrast

1. **Legal Landlord:** In Bengal, the zamindar was the legal proprietor of the soil; in the Deccan, the individual peasant (**ryot**) was the registered occupant.
2. **Demand Permanence:** Bengal's demand was fixed in perpetuity; Deccan assessments were subject to upward revision every 30 years.
3. **Agrarian Intermediary:** Bengal preserved the zamindar and produced the rich **jotedar**; the Deccan bypassed landlords, creating a direct dependency between the peasant and the usurious village moneylender (**sahukar**).

4. The Hoe and the Plough: The Hills of Rajmahal

Francis Buchanan and Colonial Cartography

Francis Buchanan (later known as Buchanan-Hamilton) was a Scottish surgeon and employee of the East India Company who conducted extensive topographic, botanical, and statistical surveys of Bengal, Bihar, and the Rajmahal hills between 1800 and 1815:

- **The Imperial Gaze:** Buchanan traveled with a vast entourage of draughtsmen, surveyors, palanquin-bearers, and coolies. His journals reveal the relentless colonial imperative to assess landscapes through the prism of commercial utility—identifying iron ore deposits, timber for ship-building, arable soil for cash crops, and tracts of "waste" land that could be brought under taxable cultivation.
- **Fear of the Forest:** Buchanan viewed the dense forests as chaotic wilderness and their inhabitants as wild, savage, and lawless, in urgent need of colonial discipline.

The Paharias: People of the Hoe

The original inhabitants of the Rajmahal hills were the **Paharias**:

- **Subsistence Economy:** They practiced shifting cultivation (**jhum**), clearing patches of forest by slashing undergrowth and burning brushwood. They used the **hoe** (**kural**) to scratch the ash-enriched soil, sowing pulses and millets for subsistence.

- **Forest Gatherers:** Their survival depended heavily on forest products: gathering **mahua** flowers for food and liquor, collecting silk cocoons and resin for sale, and cutting wood for charcoal.
- **Raids on the Plains:** In times of drought or scarcity, Paharia hillmen mounted swift guerrilla raids on settled agricultural villages in the plains, plundering grain and cattle, and levying tribute from plains zamindars and passing merchant caravans to ensure safe passage.

British Pacification and Augustus Cleveland

In the 1770s, the British initially attempted a brutal policy of extermination, sending military expeditions to hunt down and kill Paharias. When this failed to establish order:

- **Cleveland's Pacification Policy (1780s): Augustus Cleveland**, the British Collector of Bhagalpur, introduced a policy of pacification. Paharia chiefs (**sardars**) were granted annual stipends, held responsible for the good behavior of their clans, and empowered to judge minor offenses in tribal councils.
- **Retreat into the Interior:** Most Paharia clans distrusted British intentions. To preserve their cultural autonomy and avoid colonial subjugation, they retreated into the deeper, inaccessible interior ridges of the Rajmahal hills.

The Santhals: Pioneers of the Plough

Frustrated by the Paharias' stubborn refusal to clear the lowlands for settled farming, British officials turned to an immigrant tribal community: the **Santhals**:

- **Pioneers of Cultivation:** Santhals had begun migrating into Bengal from Cuttack and Chotanagpur around 1780. British officials recognized them as ideal agrarian colonizers—hardworking, disciplined, and skilled in clearing dense primeval jungle with the **plough**.
- **The Demarcation of Damin-i-Koh (1832):** In **1832**, the British demarcated a vast tract of land in the Rajmahal foothills as **Damin-i-Koh** ("the skirts of the hills"). Enclosed with masonry pillars, this designated territory was declared the exclusive homeland of the Santhals, who were required to clear at least one-tenth of the area within the first ten years.
- **Explosive Expansion:** Santhal settlement expanded with astonishing speed: from 40 villages with 3,000 people in 1838 to over 1,473 villages with over 82,000 Santhals by 1851!

5. The Santhal Hul (Rebellion) of 1855–1856

Causes of the Rebellion

Within two decades, the idyllic promises of Damin-i-Koh turned into an oppressive nightmare for the Santhals:

- **Moneylenders (Dikus):** Non-tribal merchants and moneylenders (**sahukars**, referred to contemptuously as **dikus**) penetrated the Santhal villages. They extended loans in cash and grain at usurious interest rates (often 50% to 500%), cheated illiterate Santhals with false weights, and confiscated their land, cattle, and personal liberty upon default.
- **Colonial Revenue Exactions:** The Company administration sharply increased cash land revenue assessments on Santhal villages.
- **Zamindari Encroachments:** Plains zamindars asserted legal claims over forested fringes of Damin-i-Koh, supported by corrupt colonial police (**darogas**).

The Outbreak and Leadership

In **June 1855**, the Santhals rose in a massive armed rebellion, known in tribal history as the **Santhal Hul**:

- **Messianic Leadership:** The rebellion was led by two brothers, **Sidhu** and **Kanhu Murmu**, from the village of Bhagnadih. They claimed divine visions from the supreme deity, **Thakurji**, who commanded them to slaughter oppressive moneylenders, drive out the British, and establish an independent Santhal realm (**Santhal Raj**).
- **Military Uprising:** Armed with bows, poisoned arrows, battle-axes, and spears, thousands of Santhals attacked zamindari **kacharis**, torched moneylenders' homes, and executed corrupt police officials.

Suppression and Administrative Outcome

- **Colonial Repression:** The British responded with overwhelming military force. Martial law was declared; infantry regiments and elephant brigades swept through the hills, systematically burning Santhal settlements. Over 15,000 Santhals were killed, and both Sidhu and Kanhu were captured and executed.
- **Creation of Santhal Pargana (1855):** Recognizing that unmediated exploitation threatened imperial security, the British passed the **Santhal Parganas Act of 1855**, carving out a separate administrative district of **5,500 square miles** called **Santhal Pargana** from the districts of Bhagalpur and Birbhum. Special tenancy regulations were enacted to protect tribal land from transfer to non-tribal **dikus**.

6. The Bombay Deccan: Ryotwari System, Cotton Boom & The Deccan Riots

The Ryotwari Framework in Western India

In the Bombay Deccan, conquered from the Peshwas in 1818, the British implemented the **Ryotwari system**:

- **Ricardian Principles:** British officials (influenced by economist **David Ricardo**) believed that traditional landlords pocketed agricultural surplus without investing in improvements. Under Ryotwari, the state entered into a direct revenue agreement with the actual cultivator (**ryot**).
- **Oppressive Initial Rates:** The revenue demand was fixed at extraordinary levels—often claiming over **50 percent of the gross agricultural produce**. Cultivators faced immediate destitution during crop failures, leading to large-scale peasant abandonment of villages in the 1820s and 1830s.

The American Civil War and the Cotton Boom (1861–1865)

- **Raw Cotton Crisis:** Before 1861, Britain imported three-fourths of its raw cotton from the United States. When the **American Civil War** broke out in **1861**, the Union naval blockade severed American cotton shipments to the textile factories of Lancashire.
- **Turn to the Deccan:** The British Cotton Supply Association (founded in 1857 in Manchester) and the Manchester Cotton Company (1859) turned desperately to India. Indian merchants and European export houses dispatched millions of rupees in cash advances into the Bombay Deccan to stimulate cotton cultivation.
- **The Boom:** For four years (1861–1865), credit flowed effortlessly into the countryside. Moneylenders (**sahukars**) actively encouraged ryots to borrow large sums, financing deep digging, bullock purchases, and cotton sowing. Cotton acreage in the Deccan exploded.

Post-War Crash and the Limitation Law of 1859

- **The Slump (1865):** In 1865, the American Civil War ended, and American cotton flooded British markets once again. Cotton prices in Bombay collapsed catastrophically.
- **Credit Freeze:** Local sahukars abruptly ceased advancing credit and demanded immediate repayment of existing loans.
- **The Limitation Law of 1859:** The colonial state had enacted the **Limitation Law** in **1859**, stating that loan bonds executed between moneylenders and borrowers were legally valid for only **three years**:
  - Designed to prevent the indefinite accumulation of compound interest, the law produced the exact opposite effect.
  - To prevent debts from expiring, sahukars forced illiterate ryots to sign entirely new bonds every three years, adding all unpaid accumulated interest directly into the new principal debt.
  - Sahukars refused to issue receipts for grain payments, entered fictitious loan sums, and forced ryots to sign blank papers (**kora kaghaz**).



Figure 2: Figure 2 — Chronological Trajectory of Rural Resistance & Agrarian Crisis: Sequence of rural uprisings, legislative enactments, and colonial official interventions (1780–1879 CE).

The Deccan Riots of May 1875

Pushed to the brink of total dispossession, the peasantry of the Bombay Deccan erupted in rebellion in **May 1875**:

- **Epicenter:** The revolt commenced in the large market village of **Supa** in the Poona district.
- **Course of the Riots:**
  - Ryots instituted a social boycott against moneylenders, refusing to cultivate their fields, serve as domestic helpers, or sell them provisions.
  - When boycotts failed, crowds of peasants attacked the shops and mansions of the **sahukars**.
  - Significantly, the uprising was characterized by targeted symbolic violence: peasants demanded the surrender of debt bonds, promissory notes, and account books (**bahikhatas**). They burned these documents in public bonfires in the village square.

- Physical violence against persons was rare; the sole objective was the destruction of the legal debt instruments that enslaved them.

- **Spread:** Over a few weeks, the riots swept through over 30 villages in Poona and Ahmadnagar districts before British military detachments restored order.

The Deccan Riots Commission (1878)

Alarmed by parallels with the 1857 rebellion, the Government of Bombay instituted a formal Commission of Inquiry:

- The **Deccan Riots Commission** visited affected districts, recorded statements of ryots, sahukars, and district magistrates, and collected statistical data on land auctions and debts.
- **Report to Parliament (1878):** The Commission submitted a massive report to the British Parliament in **1878**.
- **Official Bias:** Predictably, the colonial report absolved the British revenue administration of all blame, asserting that the exorbitant colonial revenue demand was not the cause of rural distress. Instead, the report attributed peasant bankruptcy entirely to the deceitful usury of moneylenders and the peasant's alleged "reckless expenditure" on marriages and festivals.
- **Legislative Concession:** To mitigate rural unrest, the government passed the **Deccan Agriculturists' Relief Act of 1879**, ensuring that peasants could not be arrested or imprisoned for debt default.

Buchanan's Gaze: The Landscape as Commodity

Francis Buchanan's meticulous diaries provide extraordinary insight into how the colonial state evaluated Indian geography:

- **The Landscape of Utility:** When Buchanan climbed the Rajmahal hills, he did not record the scenic beauty or the sacred groves revered by the Paharias. Instead, he systematically noted the commercial viability of mineral veins, the thickness of sal forests for railway sleepers, and the precise acreage of 'wasteland' that could be converted into taxable paddy fields.
- **The Concept of 'Wasteland':** Under British political economy, any forest or pasture not subject to sedentary plough cultivation and state land tax was classified as **wasteland** (**ghair-mazrua**). This ideological construct served as the moral justification for dispossessing indigenous hunter-gatherers and handing their ancestral territories over to immigrant settled cultivators.

The Santhal Memory of the Hul: Vernacular Folklore & Resistance Songs

While British military dispatches depicted the Santhal rebellion as an irrational outbreak of savage violence, Santhal oral songs preserved in tribal memory reveal a profound subaltern consciousness:

- **Songs of the Hul:** Tribal bards (**karanis**) sang: 'O Sidhu, why are you bathed in blood? O Kanhu, why are your clothes red with gore? Because the dikus have taken our cattle, the police have burned our homes, and our great god Thakurji has handed us the holy battle-axe!'
- **A Struggle for Moral Order:** The Santhal rebellion was not merely a protest against debt; it was an apocalyptic struggle to restore moral order (**dhorom**), reclaim ancestral lands, and overthrow an alien, corrupt regime that had desecrated their sacred forests.

Colonial Law vs Rural Morality: The Rupture of Peasant-Creditor Relations

In pre-colonial western India, the relationship between peasant cultivators and village moneylenders was governed by traditional moral norms known as **Damdupat**:

- **The Rule of Damdupat:** Under customary Hindu and regional law, the total interest charged on a debt could never exceed the principal sum borrowed. This traditional ceiling protected cultivators from endless compound accumulation.
- **Colonial Judicial Disruption:** British civil courts completely disregarded customary moral economies, enforcing the strict, literal terms of written contracts. Armed with colonial warrants, sahukars claimed interest that was ten or twenty times the original loan, shattering rural social peace and driving peasants toward the violent bonfires of Supa in 1875.

7. Official Reports as Historical Sources: Navigating Colonial Bias

To interpret colonial history accurately, students of history must navigate the deep structural biases inherent in imperial archives:

The Nature of the Colonial Archive

Every official document—from Buchanan's surveys and the Fifth Report to the Deccan Riots Commission—was generated by the colonial state to serve specific administrative, fiscal, and political objectives:

- **Instrumental Vision:** Land was recorded in terms of revenue potential, forests as merchantable timber or obstacles to cultivation, and peasants as taxable subjects.
- **Historiographical Pitfalls:** Accepting official reports uncritically leads to adopting the colonizer's worldview. Historians must read "against the grain," comparing official dispatches with vernacular petitions, oral memories, folk ballads, and judicial records to reconstruct the authentic experiences, agency, and worldview of subaltern rural communities.

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Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap

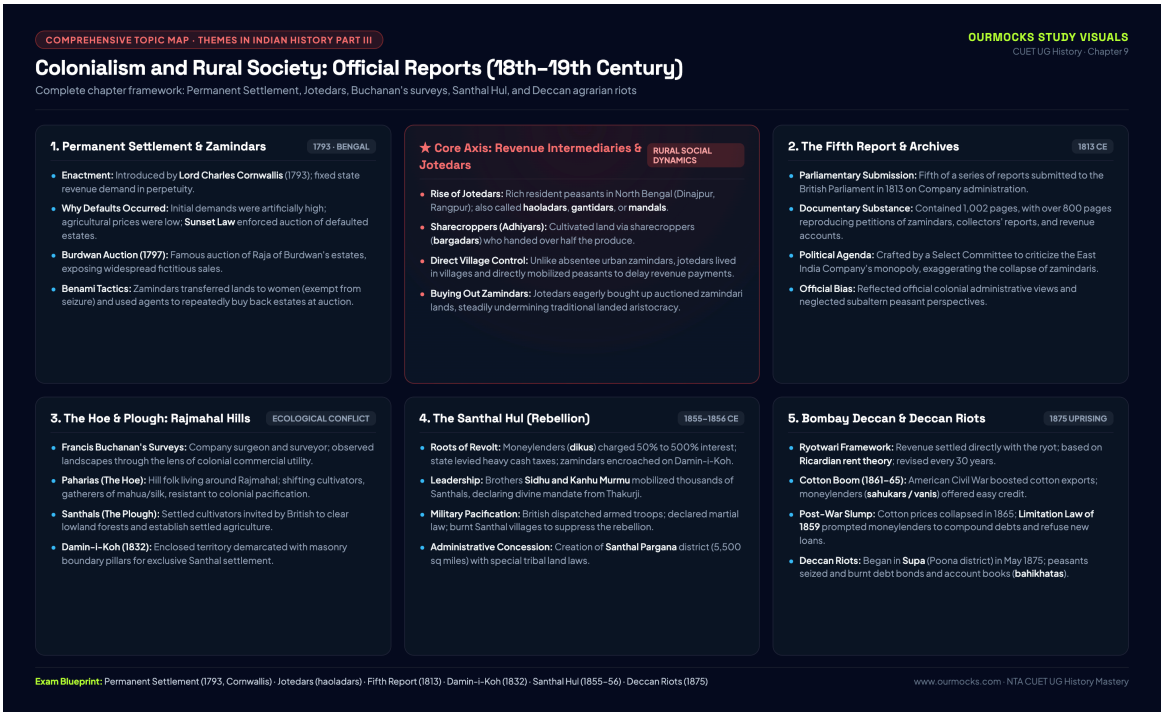


Figure 3: Figure 3 — Colonialism and Rural Society Summary Mindmap: Complete synthesis of the Permanent Settlement, Jotedar dynamics, Fifth Report archives, the hoe vs plough, the Santhal Hul, and the Deccan peasant uprising.

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL POINTERS

- **The Sunset Law Clause:** Payment had to reach the collectorate before sunset of the appointed date; failure triggered mandatory confiscation and public auction of the zamindari estate.
- **Benami Transaction Artifice:** Fictitious purchases made in the name of servants, retainers, and female family members (exempt from seizure) preserved major estates like Burdwan from actual disintegration.
- **Jotedar Synonyms across Bengal: Haoladars** in eastern Bengal; **Gantidars** or **Mandals** in northern Bengal; all functioned as resident village headmen wielding direct dominance over sharecroppers (**adhiyars** / **bargadars**).
- **The Two Tools of Rajmahal: Hoe** (**kural**) = Paharia shifting subsistence cultivation; **Plough** = Santhal settled taxable agriculture backed by British colonial policy.
- **Damin-i-Koh (1832):** The "skirts of the hills" demarcated with boundary pillars for Santhal settlement; transformed into the **Santhal Pargana** district (5,500 sq miles) in 1855 after the rebellion.
- **Limitation Law of 1859:** Three-year validity of debt bonds weaponized by moneylenders to compound interest into new principal, trapping illiterate Deccan ryots in generational debt.
- **Supa Village (Poona):** The historic spark of the May 1875 Deccan Riots, where account books (**bahikhatas**) and debt bonds were publicly burned.

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — COLONIALISM AND RURAL SOCIETY

▸**Permanent Settlement (1793):** Enacted by Lord Cornwallis in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa; fixed state revenue demand in perpetuity; converted rajas/taluqdars into legal landlords; strictly enforced via the Sunset Law. ▸**Jotedar Dominance:** Rich resident peasants who owned thousands of acres, controlled rural moneylending, rented land to sharecroppers (**adhiyars** / **bargadars**), and actively resisted absentee zamindars. ▸**The Fifth Report (1813):** 1,002-page British Parliamentary Select Committee report on Company misrule; exaggerated zamindari ruin to justify revoking the East India Company's trade monopoly. ▸**Damin-i-Koh (1832):** Forested foothill territory demarcated for Santhals to practice sedentary plough agriculture; sparked the Santhal Hul (1855–56) led by Sidhu and Kanhu against usurious **dikus**. ▸**Ryotwari System:** Operational in Bombay and Madras; inspired by David Ricardo's rent theory; eliminated intermediaries to assess revenue directly on individual peasants; revised every 30 years. ▸**Deccan Cotton Boom & Slump:** Triggered by the American Civil War (1861–65); collapsed in 1865, resulting in credit freeze, peasant bankruptcy, and the May 1875 riots at Supa (burning of **bahikhatas**).

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS

1. **Trap 1 (Jotedars as Absentee Landlords):** Assuming Jotedars lived in cities. Jotedars were rich **resident** peasants living directly in villages, whereas zamindars resided in urban centers (Calcutta).
2. **Trap 2 (Complete Collapse of Zamindaris):** Believing all Bengal zamindaris collapsed post-1793. Great zamindars survived by **benami** sales, transferring land to women, and using armed **lathyals**.
3. **Trap 3 (Tool Symbolism Inversion):** Matching Santhals with the hoe and Paharias with the plough. Paharias used the **hoe** (shifting cultivation); Santhals used the **plough** (settled farming).
4. **Trap 4 (Limitation Law of 1859 Interest Rate):** Assuming the law capped interest at 3%. The law capped the **legal validity of loan bonds** at 3 years, which moneylenders exploited by forcing triennial renewals.
5. **Trap 5 (Violence Target in Deccan Riots):** Believing peasants murdered moneylenders or looted British treasuries. The rioters engaged in **symbolic violence**, solely destroying debt bonds and **bahi-khatas**.
6. **Trap 6 (Deccan Riots Commission Exoneration):** Assuming the Commission criticized high colonial revenue rates. The report deliberately exonerated the state, blaming greedy moneylenders and peasant improvidence.
7. **Trap 7 (Damin-i-Koh vs Santhal Pargana):** Damin-i-Koh was established in **1832** for settlement; Santhal Pargana was carved out in **1855** as a district following the suppression of the Santhal Hul.

Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

Part 1: Bengal, Permanent Settlement & The Fifth Report (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. The Permanent Settlement of land revenue was introduced in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa in 1793 under which British Governor-General?

(A) Lord Warren Hastings
(B) Lord Charles Cornwallis
(C) Lord Richard Wellesley
(D) Lord William Bentinck

Sol. Q1. Governor-General of Permanent Settlement:

- The Permanent Settlement was introduced in **1793** by **Lord Charles Cornwallis**.
- It converted traditional rajas and taluqdars into landlords (zamindars) and fixed state revenue demand in perpetuity.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q2. Under the colonial 'Sunset Law' operating within the Permanent Settlement framework, what was the mandatory consequence if a zamindar failed to clear his revenue installment?

(A) The zamindar was sentenced to rigorous imprisonment for life
(B) The zamindar's private army was merged with the British infantry
(C) His estate was immediately confiscated and auctioned to the highest bidder
(D) The revenue assessment was permanently reduced by fifty percent

Sol. Q2. Mechanics of the Sunset Law:

- The Sunset Law stipulated that if revenue was not deposited by sunset of the appointed date, the zamindari estate was liable to be auctioned.
- Over 75% of estates were sold off in the decades following 1793 due to this rigid clause.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q3. In the agrarian hierarchy of North Bengal, what was the designation given to the class of rich resident peasants who owned thousands of acres and dominated local village moneylending?

(A) Jotedars
(B) Adhiyars
(C) Bargadars
(D) Lathyals

Sol. Q3. Identification of Jotedars:

- Rich resident peasants in North Bengal (Dinajpur, Rangpur) were known as **Jotedars** (also called **haoladars**, **gantidars**, or **mandals**).
- They lived in villages, controlled local moneylending and grain trade, and rented land to sharecroppers (**adhiyars** / **bargadars**).

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q4. In the official archives of British colonial governance, what was the primary political motivation behind the submission of the celebrated 'Fifth Report' to Parliament in 1813?

(A) To celebrate the agricultural prosperity of the Bengal peasantry under Company rule
(B) To advocate the total replacement of the Permanent Settlement with the Ryotwari system
(C) To encourage large-scale Christian missionary activities across rural Bihar
(D) To critique Company misgovernance and lobby against the East India Company's trade monopoly

Sol. Q4. Political Purpose of the Fifth Report:

- The **Fifth Report** (1813) was drafted by a Parliamentary Select Committee to highlight Company administrative corruption and financial disorder.
- British merchants used it to lobby Parliament to revoke the Company's commercial monopoly via the Charter Act of 1813.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q5. Which agricultural implement was deployed by NCERT historians as a powerful metaphor to symbolize the settled, taxable agrarian frontier promoted by the British in the Rajmahal hills?

(A) The Plough
(B) The Hoe
(C) The Sickle
(D) The Persian Wheel

Sol. Q5. Metaphor of the Hoe and the Plough:

- In NCERT, **The Plough** symbolized the settled agriculture of the Santhals backed by the colonial state.
- **The Hoe** (**kural**) symbolized the shifting subsistence cultivation of the Paharias who resisted colonial sedentary control.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Part 2: Rajmahal Hills, Santhal Hul & Ryotwari Settlement (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. In 1832, the British colonial administration demarcated a large enclosed tract of land in the Rajmahal foothills for exclusive Santhal colonization known as:

(A) Damin-i-Koh (B) Chotanagpur
(C) Kolhan (D) Santhal Pargana

Sol. Q6. Demarcation of Damin-i-Koh:

- In **1832**, the British demarcated **Damin-i-Koh** ("the skirts of the hills") with masonry boundary pillars.
- Santhals were given land grants here on the condition that they clear forests and practice settled plough agriculture.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q7. The historic Santhal Hul (Rebellion) of 1855–1856 was led by which two brothers from the village of Bhagnadih who claimed divine sanction from Thakurji?

(A) Birsa and Komal Munda (B) Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu
(C) Tilka and Jitu Majhi (D) Alluri and Rama Raju

Sol. Q7. Leadership of the Santhal Hul:

- The Santhal Rebellion of 1855–56 was led by brothers **Sidhu** and **Kanhu Murmu** of Bhagnadih.
- They proclaimed that their supreme deity, **Thakurji**, had commanded them to eliminate usurious moneylenders (**dikus**) and establish an independent Santhal Raj.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q8. Following the military suppression of the 1855–1856 tribal rebellion, what special administrative district did the colonial government carve out to pacify the Santhals?

(A) Damin-i-Koh Division (B) Bhagalpur Hill Tracts
(C) Santhal Pargana (D) Ranchi Autonomous District

Sol. Q8. Creation of Santhal Pargana:

- Recognizing the danger of unmediated tribal exploitation, the British enacted the **Santhal Parganas Act of 1855**.
- It carved out a separate administrative district of **5,500 square miles** called **Santhal Pargana** from Bhagalpur and Birbhum.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q9. The economic rent theory of which classical European political economist provided the primary intellectual justification for the Ryotwari system in western India?

(A) Adam Smith (B) Thomas Malthus
(C) John Stuart Mill (D) David Ricardo

Sol. Q9. Ricardian Rent Theory and Ryotwari:

- British officials in western India were heavily influenced by economist **David Ricardo**.
- Ricardo argued that the state should directly tax surplus economic rent from the actual cultivator (**ryot**), eliminating parasitic landlord intermediaries.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q10. Which external international geopolitical crisis triggered an unprecedented 'Cotton Boom' in the Bombay Deccan between 1861 and 1865?

(A) The Crimean War (B) The American Civil War
(C) The Franco-Prussian War (D) The First Opium War

Sol. Q10. The American Civil War & Cotton Boom:

- When the **American Civil War** broke out in **1861**, the Union blockade severed American raw cotton shipments to Lancashire textile mills.
- British merchants rushed advances into the Bombay Deccan, triggering an explosive expansion of cotton cultivation and credit from 1861 to 1865.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Part 3: Deccan Riots, Official Commissions & Historiography (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. Enacted by the colonial state in 1859, the 'Limitation Law' stipulated that loan bonds executed between moneylenders and borrowers were legally valid for only:

(A) One year (B) Two years
(C) Three years (D) Five years

Sol. Q11. Terms of the Limitation Law of 1859:

- The **Limitation Law of 1859** stated that loan bonds were legally valid for only **three years**.
- Moneylenders turned this against peasants by forcing them to execute new bonds every three years, adding unpaid interest directly into the new principal.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q12. In May 1875, the agrarian uprising known as the Deccan Riots first broke out in which prominent market village of the Poona district?

(A) Supa (B) Koregaon
(C) Baramati (D) Junnar

Sol. Q12. Origin of the Deccan Riots:

- The Deccan Riots erupted in **May 1875** in the large market village of **Supa** in Poona district.
- Ryots instituted social boycotts against moneylenders and attacked shops to seize and burn debt documents.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q13. During the Deccan Riots of May 1875, what was the primary target of peasant crowds attacking the establishments of village moneylenders (sahukars)?

(A) Imperial treasury vaults (B) Storehouses of British arms and ammunition
(C) Gold and silver jewelry (D) Debt bonds, promissory notes, and account books (bahi-khatas)

Sol. Q13. Primary Target of the Deccan Riots:

- Peasants engaged in targeted **symbolic violence**, seeking the destruction of legal debt instruments: loan bonds, promissory notes, and account books (**bahikhatas**).
- These documents were dragged into the village square and burned in public bonfires.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q14. The official Deccan Riots Commission Report presented to the British Parliament in 1878 concluded that rural indebtedness and peasant insolvency were caused by:

(A) The crushing burden of the colonial state's high land revenue demand (B) The deceitful usury of moneylenders and alleged peasant extravagance on ceremonies
(C) The widespread destruction of cotton crops by locust plagues (D) Subversive anti-British agitation orchestrated by the descendants of the Peshwa

Sol. Q14. Findings of the Deccan Riots Commission:

- The official Commission deliberately **absolved the colonial revenue administration** of all culpability.
- It attributed peasant distress entirely to the dishonest usury of moneylenders (**sahukars**) and the alleged "reckless expenditure" of peasants on marriages and ceremonies.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q15. Which Scottish surgeon and official surveyor traveled across Bengal, Bihar, and the Rajmahal hills compiling exhaustive topographic and statistical surveys for the East India Company?

(A) Colin Mackenzie (B) Alexander Greenlaw
(C) Francis Buchanan (D) Augustus Cleveland

Sol. Q15. Surveys of Francis Buchanan:

- Dr. **Francis Buchanan** (Buchanan-Hamilton) was a surgeon and surveyor who surveyed Bengal, Bihar, and the Rajmahal hills (1800–1815).
- His detailed journals reflect the colonial state's relentless drive to identify natural resources, timber, and arable lands for taxable exploitation.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**